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UAE among the most AI-ready Gulf economies

IMF SAYS TECH INVESTMENT TO SHAPE REGION'S NEXT PHASE OF GROWTH

DUBAI
BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

The UAE is among the most prepared Gulf economies for artificial-intelligence adoption, according to the International Monetary Fund (IMF), which says the country's investment in technology and education is positioning it for sustained growth.

"Three countries from the GCC are among the best in terms of readiness — Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and the UAE," said Jihad Azour, Director of the IMF's Middle East and Central Asia Department, as the Fund announced growth projections for the Mena region.

The IMF projects the Middle East, North Africa and Pakistan to grow 3.2 per cent in 2025 and 3.7 per cent in 2026. The Fund had in an earlier report pegged the UAE economy to expand by 4.8 per cent in 2025, following an estimated 4.0 per cent in 2024, well above the global average.

AI's wider impact

Speaking at a media briefing in Dubai, he said future investment in "technology, AI, data centres and the internet of the future" would define the next growth cycle. "Those investments are expected to yield results in terms of growth and increasing investment," he added.

Azour noted that AI's impact will extend far beyond technol-

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ogy. "AI is going to change the way we work. Forty per cent of the labour force will be affected," he said. "Access to technology for youth, start-ups and SMEs is very important at an affordable price."

He stressed that readiness depends on education and skills. "Investment in education and in talent will be essential," he said. "Readiness is something that is very important to expand beyond the three countries, for several countries in the region to be able to benefit and compete."

Asked about overheating in the fast-growing AI sector, Azour said the region's financial systems remain sound. "The financial system is well regulated with strong levels of capitalisation and buffers, which would protect it from any asset adjustment," he said. "Education is very important to build the skills in the region."

He said the Gulf's young, tech-savvy population will be central to the transition. "More than two thirds of our population is below 30, tech savvy and has the capacity to increase their skills," he said.

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AFP

JAPAN'S FIRST WOMAN PRIME MINISTER TAKES CHARGE

Liberal Democratic Party (LDP) President Sanae Takaichi stands up to acknowledge the applause after she was selected as Japan's new Prime Minister during an extraordinary session of the lower house of parliament in Tokyo yesterday. The 64-year-old, a conservative lawmaker known for her admiration for Margaret Thatcher, inherits an LDP struggling with falling public support, inflation, and a slush-fund scandal that has eroded its once-dominant base.

UAE gold prices plunge by Dh30

In Dubai, 24k gold sank below Dh500-mark after long time

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

In the UAE, gold prices plunged by nearly Dh30 per gram yesterday evening, after hitting a new record just hours earlier — tracking a sudden price drop of as much as 6 per cent.

In Dubai, 24-carat gold currently costs Dh495, dropping below the Dh500-mark after a long while, while the price

of 22-carat reached Dh458 per gram.

Earlier in the day, gold price opened at record Dh525.25 per gram and 22-carat reached Dh486 — same as yesterday's prices.

Biggest drop since 2013

Globally, gold plunged the most since 2013 while silver had its biggest drop since 2021 yesterday amid a broad market sell-off of precious metals.

Spot gold fell as much as 6.3 per cent to \$4,082.03 an ounce, marking the biggest decline since mid-April 2013. Spot silver fell as much as 8.7 per cent to \$47.89 an ounce,

the biggest decline since February 2021. "Gold and silver face heavy sell-off as trade tensions between US and China ease," explained Daniela Hathorn, senior market analyst at Capital.com.

"Gold and silver staged an impressive rally in recent weeks that led the precious metals to break several record highs. The momentum was driven by safe haven demand on the back of escalating geopolitical tensions and fiscal constraints, expectations of lower rates from the Federal Reserve, and improved fundamentals. However, the upside has run out of steam this week."

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